

Reflections from the Gateways26 Faculty Hack Conference

Attending the Gateways26 Faculty Hack Conference in Washington, D.C., from September 23–26, 2026, was a valuable and energizing experience. As a Faculty Hack participant, I presented my poster, *Where Bayous Meet Bytes: A Cloud-Powered Ecology CURE for Biology Majors*, which highlights my redesign of ECOL 404B Ecology at Southern University and A&M College. My poster presentation went well, and I appreciated the thoughtful questions, feedback, and conversations from colleagues interested in technology, science, teaching, and student access to computational tools.

The conference sessions were engaging and informative. Some sessions aligned more closely with my work than others, but each offered useful ideas about Science Gateways, teaching innovation, collaboration, and the responsible integration of technology into learning environments. I especially valued hearing how other educators and researchers are using advanced computing, AI, and digital infrastructure to support students and broaden participation in STEM.

The Fishbowl discussion on the final day was a true highlight. That session created space for honest reflection, shared experiences, and meaningful dialogue among participants. It reminded me that innovation in teaching is not only about tools; it is also about community, access, sustainability, and student-centered design.

Overall, Gateways26 strengthened my excitement about continuing this work. I left with new ideas, stronger professional connections, and renewed motivation to keep building accessible Science Gateway experiences for my biology majors. I am already looking forward to collaborating with friends for the 2027 conference in San Diego, California.